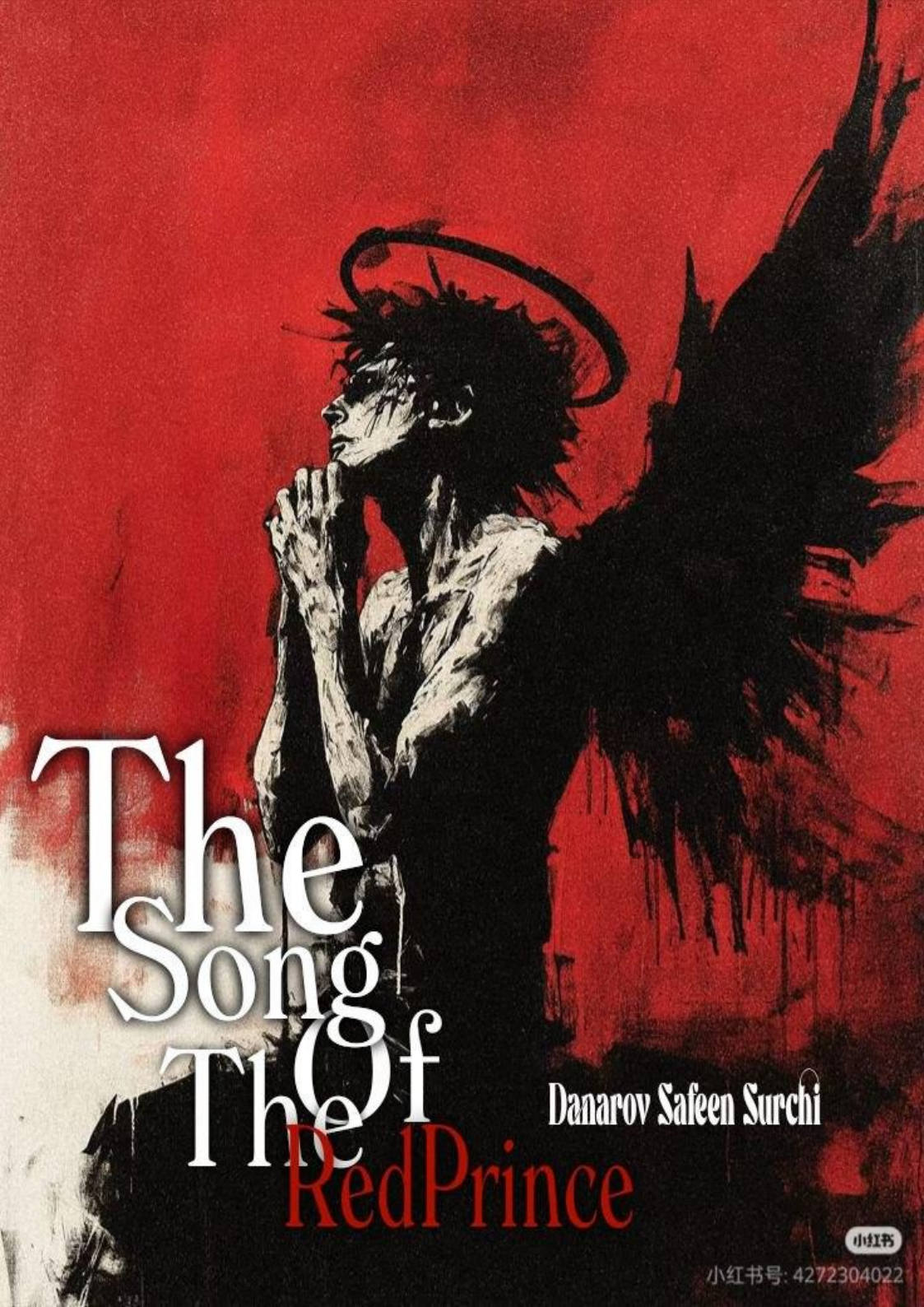




The Song Of The Red Prince

Danarov Safeen Surchi

小红书

小红书号: 4272304022

The waves moved the boat, carrying
the exiled boy away from the only place
he had ever known. The salty wind
struck his eyes, sharp and stinging, but
.he did not cry

.Because he knew

He knew that tears would not bring
.back what he had lost

The boy I speak of is Prince Donarall of
Aelardenia, son of kings and prince of
Redcastle. He was born in the year
.1350 A.S.C

His fingers tightened as memories of
his final moments in the palace
returned. His father had fought bravely

against their enemies. He could still hear the screams of old women, still see the blood staining the ground, and the red sky looming over the castle like .an omen of ruin

Lost in his thoughts, he suddenly felt a pair of heavy, aged hands grip his .shoulder

It was his father's loyal knight. The man studied his face for a moment, then :spoke

”.We are safe now, my prince“

His voice was calm and strong, yet exhaustion lingered beneath it. Then he ‘added

The army of Starfire will not chase us “

”across the sea

The prince did not answer. He could not. His heart felt shattered—tight and heavy in his chest, as if even breathing .required strength he no longer had

The boat continued its journey toward a distant, unfamiliar island called Highmontania—a land that, in time, ...would become his home

.or his curse—

.It did not matter to him

He did not care what awaited him .there

The only thing that mattered... was that —one day, he would return

.and take back what was his

After three months in Highmontania,
.the days had grown calmer

That day was beautiful. The weather
was warm, and the sun shone brightly,
bathing the village in a rare moment of
.peace

The prince had begun to grow used to
the villagers. He lived among them
now, alongside his father's loyal
knight—both of them bound together
.in exile

On that day, he sat with the village's
elder, a man known for his wisdom. The
old man's name was Gohaka

Gohaka looked at the children gathered
before him and asked

My boys... who knows what happened “
”to Ser Fredrick Darkgar

The prince spoke immediately, without
hesitation



:

A thousand years ago, he lived during “the Snake Lord’s Rebellion. He served whoever stood in his path—whoever paid him. But over the years, he grew tired of it. So he decided to build his own realm. He killed all who stood in his way. He was a cannibal—he ate the flesh of his enemies and called their blood wine. ‘Darkgar’ means dark devil. Some stories say he traveled far to the east, across forgotten lands and seas, to a place called Romeneria. And after all these years... some say he is still
”.alive

The old man smiled, clearly surprised
.by the boy’s knowledge

”You know much, boy... well done“

.Then he turned to the other children

He speaks the truth. A thousand years “
”—ago

Before he could finish, a villager
approached and spoke quickly in the
Holiana language, words the children
.could not understand

Gohaka’s expression changed. The calm
in his eyes faded, replaced by
something heavier... something close to
.sorrow

He looked back at the children and
‘said

”.Go on now... go play your games“

.The children stood and began to leave

But before the prince could go, the old
‘man called out

”.You... stay, boy“

.The prince remained

Gohaka took a deep breath before

.speaking again, his voice quieter now

Your knight... the Red God has given “

”.him peace

.The knight had died

.The boy broke

He cried out loudly, his body shaking as

.he struggled against the truth

No... no, it can't be... please! It can't "
"!be—I can't... please

The villagers tried to comfort him, but
.their words meant nothing

—In that moment

.something within him changed

That was the moment the prince was
.truly born

...After ten years

In the early morning of a warm summer
day, he stood upon the beach, his eyes
narrowed toward the horizon—toward
his home. His empire. His legacy, now
.held in the iron grip of his enemies

His hand tightened around the hilt of his sword. He took a deep breath, then turned away and walked back to the place where his guardian, the wise old man Gohoko, taught children history and manners

‘He spoke firmly

”.Leave us“

The children rose and quietly departed. Gohoko looked at him with curiosity, but said nothing

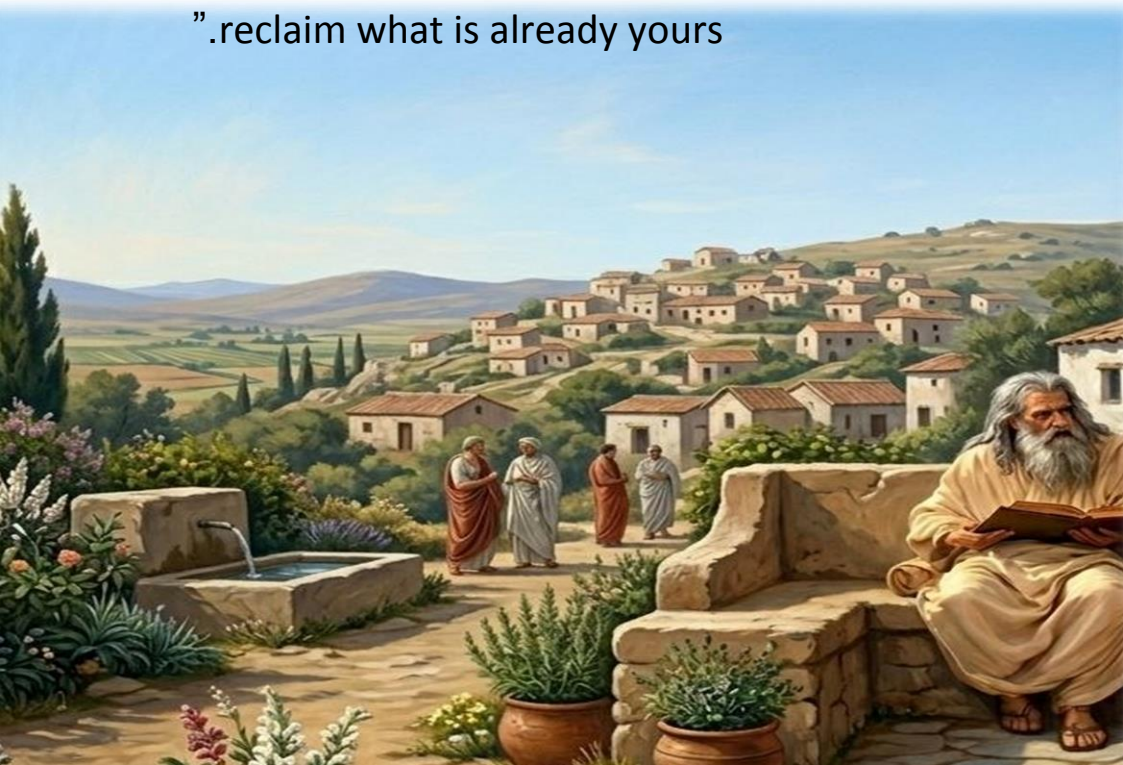


He sat beside him, then the prince
broke the silence.

”I want to go back“

The old man drew in a slow breath, as if
he had long been expecting these
.words

I cannot stop you... and you deserve to “
”.reclaim what is already yours



The prince had prepared himself for
.resistance—anything but acceptance

.He simply nodded

he returned to the small house he
shared with Gohoko and gathered his
belongings. When he was finished, he
came back and stood before the old
man

”.Thank you“

Gohoko looked into his eyes, warmth in
.his gaze, like that of a father

We will meet again. But when we do... “
you will be changed. Try not to return
”.as someone you are not

The prince frowned, confused by his
.words

Then the old man stood and embraced
.him

For a moment, the prince was still—
surprised. Then he softened, returning
.the embrace

‘By evening
.his journey had begun

His journey was long.

When he finally reached his homeland, he walked toward the city. But midway along the road, ten bandits stepped out and blocked his path.

His hand moved to the hilt of his sword—the blade he had named ColdWinter. It stood nearly as tall as he did, only twenty-five centimeters shorter than his own height.

One of the bandits sneered and said, “Give us gold... or your life.”

The prince answered coldly, without hesitation,

“I will give you nothing but cold, sharp

steel.”

The bandit leader laughed.

“Then we will take it.”

They raised their weapons—and so did he.

Some of them hesitated, fear creeping into their eyes. How could one man wield such a sword?

They had no time to think.

With a single swing, he struck first—cutting down three of them at once.

Another rushed from behind, aiming for his shoulder. The prince twisted away, and with a half-turn, drove his blade deep into the man’s belly.

Three more attacked together.

One aimed for his head—he blocked.

Another struck from the side—he

deflected.

A third lunged for his chest—he turned it aside.

Then came a strike toward his legs.

He leapt.

In midair, his blade flashed—and when it landed, one man's head fell from his body.

He fought them all—
well, and without mercy.

Soon, only two remained.

They dropped their swords and fell to their knees, trembling.

One of them wept as he begged,

“Please, my lord... spare me. I swear I will never do this again. Please... I beg you.”

The prince lowered his sword until its



tip touched the ground. He placed both hands upon the hilt and looked at them with a faint smile..

“God has mercy.”

Relief spread across their faces. For a brief moment, they believed they would live.

Then his smile faded—into something darker.

His voice became calm... and cold.

“But I am not God.”

In a single motion, his blade swept through the air—
and both heads fell.

Without another word,
his journey toward home began again

As he entered the city,
he saw it—the great city of Redcastle. It
still held its glory, but under the iron
grip of its enemies, it was broken...
diminished.

The people lived in a harsh age of
slavery. Their souls felt heavy beneath
the weight of mental, emotional, and
physical suffering.

He walked through the streets like a
ghost, silent and unseen, making his
way toward the great tavern at the
heart of the city.

As he entered, he noticed a young boy
moving through the room.

He reached out, grabbing the boy's
shoulder firmly, and said,

“Go. Tell everyone... the RedPrince is

here.”

The boy looked up, fear in his eyes at the sight of the towering figure before him. He swallowed, bowed quickly, and ran out of the tavern.

The prince took a seat and called out, “Bring me wine.”

Moments later, a servant approached with a bottle. The prince took it and drank in silence.

Then two large men rose from their seats. One of them stepped behind him and placed a heavy hand on his shoulder.

The swordsman spoke, “Who are you?”

The RedPrince turned slowly.

The moment they saw his face, both

men froze.

One of them stammered,

“P—Prince... Donarall of Redcastle?”

Before another word could be spoken,
they both dropped to their knees.

From the edges of the room, two more
men stepped forward—and they knelt
as well.

But another man turned and rushed
out, intending to carry the news to the
authorities.

An arrow struck him before he reached
the door.

He fell dead.

One by one, they swore their loyalty to
the rightful heir.

And his goal?

Still far away—
but now... closer than ever before.

As he gathered loyal men around him,
they began meeting in secret within the
abandoned, half-ruined palace that
once belonged to his bloodline.

Night after night, they struck enemy
military outposts, vanishing before
reinforcements could arrive.

The name of the RedPrince soon
echoed through the neighborhoods of
the great city. It spread like fire through
taverns, alleyways, markets, and
hidden corners where hope had long
been buried.

The patience of the usurper
government began to crack.
Their generals grew furious and

desperate, commanding their soldiers to find the prince immediately.

As the days passed, the people themselves began rising in rebellion.

But each uprising ended the same way—bloodshed, executions, and failure.

So the prince sent one of his men to the great temple of religion. In the prince's name, the messenger begged the people to stop their reckless revolts.

The time for open war had not yet come.

But tonight... would change everything. Tonight's mission was perhaps the hardest they had ever faced.

They would attack the North Base—the

most heavily protected military fortress within Redcastle.

The prince and his men were badly outnumbered.

Yet he knew it had to be done.

They gathered around the old war table inside the ruined palace hall. Dust covered the cracked stone walls, and the remains of burned banners still hung above them like ghosts of a dead kingdom.

The prince stood at the head of the table and spoke firmly,

“Tonight, we attack the North Base.”

Beside him stood Ser Gregora, a hardened knight in his late fifties. His hair was grey and thinning, his face marked with scars earned through

decades of war. One blind eye stared lifelessly ahead while the other remained sharp and watchful. Confusion crossed his face as he asked, “Forgive me, Your Grace... but do you know how many men guard the North Base?”

The prince nodded silently.

Then Ser Brokan spoke. He was younger than Gregora, a broad and powerful man in his thirties with a thick beard, dark hair, and heavy armor scarred by countless battles.

“But, Your Grace... it will be a bloody night.”

At last, the prince looked up. His voice was calm, though it sounded as though he were forcing himself to contain the

fire within him.

“You swore loyalty to me. I forced none of you. If you are afraid, you may leave. I need brave men, not cowards.”

He paused for a moment before continuing,

“We leave at midnight. Anyone who does not wish to come... then do not come.”

The prince did not wait for their answer.

He turned and walked out of the broken hall, leaving only silence behind him.

As the night began, the prince’s men hid their cloaks beneath piles of rubble and moved forward toward a place many of them knew they might never

return from.

They climbed the massive walls slowly and silently, killing the guards before a single cry could escape into the night. After clearing their path, they advanced toward the general's palace.

But halfway there—
the bells rang.

They had been discovered.

Panic spread among some of the men, but the prince needed no more than five seconds to change the entire plan. Before enemy reinforcements could arrive, he shouted,

“Burn the supply keep! Free the prisoners—give them daggers! Then leave!”

His soldiers obeyed instantly, without a

second thought.

They stormed through the fortress, setting fire to every supply house they reached. The prison cells were broken open, and the prisoners poured out like starving wolves finally freed from their chains.

Weapons were handed to them—three daggers each.

Then chaos consumed the fortress.

The prisoners burned whatever they could reach and attacked the enemy soldiers with madness in their eyes.

When reinforcements finally arrived, a brutal battle erupted within the flames and smoke.

The prisoners were eventually crushed.

But before they fell...
they wounded the enemy badly.

When they finally returned to their
hideout, Ser Gregoria looked at the
prince with fury burning in his eyes.

“Was this what you wanted, boy?! To
lose our men out there?” he shouted.

“That mission was the work of a fool!”

The prince answered calmly,

“This sounds like treason, my lord.”

At once, several soldiers gripped the
hilts of their swords.

Then the prince spoke again, his voice
cold and firm:

“Take Lord Gregoria to the dungeon.”

The soldiers stepped forward to seize
him, but Gregoria drew his sword
before they could touch him.

His face twisted with rage, though his voice remained strangely calm.

“You did not ask politely... did you?”

The prince stared directly into his eyes.

“No. I did not.”

Gregoria raised his blade. Instantly, the others raised theirs as well.

But the prince commanded,

“Lower your swords.”

The men hesitated.

“If I die, then he is free. But if I win... there will be no mercy for a traitor.”

Slowly, the soldiers lowered their weapons and stepped back, watching in silence as the prince and the old knight faced one another.

Gregoria struck first.

His blade smashed into the prince’s

knee, forcing him down to one leg. Pain shot through him as he nearly collapsed.

The knight moved immediately for the killing blow, swinging toward the prince's head.

But in that instant, the prince pulled a dagger from his belt and drove it deep into Gregoria's wrist.

The old knight cried out, struggling not to lose his sword.

That moment was enough.

The prince rose to his feet and thrust ColdWinter forward—straight through Gregoria's head.

The knight's body fell heavily onto the cold stone floor.

And silence filled the hall.

The hall remained silent after the fall of Ser Gregoria.

Blood slowly spread across the ancient stone floor beneath the old knight's corpse. No one moved. No one dared to speak.

Prince Donarall stood motionless, his sword still buried in Gregoria's skull. Then, slowly, he pulled ColdWinter free.

The sound of steel scraping against bone echoed through the ruined hall like a scream.

Some of the younger soldiers looked away. Others stared at him with fear for the very first time.

Not fear of defeat.

Fear of him.

The prince turned toward them, his face unreadable. Blood dripped from the edge of his sword onto the floor.

“Anyone else?” he asked calmly.

No one answered.

At last, Ser Brokan stepped forward and dropped to one knee.

“Forgive us, Your Grace. Doubt has poisoned this hall.”

One by one, the others followed.

Kneeling before the RedPrince.

Donarall looked at them for a long moment before speaking again.

“Fear is natural. Betrayal is not.”

He walked past Gregoria’s body and toward the shattered throne at the end of the hall—the broken throne of his ancestors.

For years it had sat abandoned beneath
dust and darkness.

Now, the prince stood before it in
silence.

Then he sat down.

The hall felt colder the moment he did.

Outside, thunder rolled across the
distant skies above Redcastle.

The prince rested ColdWinter beside
the throne and looked down upon the
kneeling men before him.

“Tomorrow,” he said quietly, “we stop
hiding.”

The men slowly lifted their heads.

Donarall’s eyes had changed. Whatever
softness remained inside the exiled boy
from Highmontania was fading more
with every drop of blood spilled in his

name.

“Send ravens across the city. Burn our symbol into every enemy gate.”

His voice remained calm.

Too calm.

“Let them know their prince has returned.”

The following night, they gathered once again within the ruined palace to plan another attack.

Word had reached them that the enemy general would soon be traveling through the eastern roads.

The prince pointed toward a narrow vale marked upon the old map spread across the table.

“When they pass through this valley,” he said, “we strike from the mountains

with arrows and surround the road
below. Is that clear, boys?"

His eyes moved between the men.

"Yes, my prince," they answered
together. "It is clear."

The prince nodded.

"Then go. Prepare yourselves."

The soldiers bowed before leaving the
hall one by one.

When they were gone, the prince
turned toward his lover, Maesha.

She stood near the war table, the
candlelight dancing softly across her
face.

Donarall sat before her and spoke
quietly,

"Tonight... or never."

Maesha looked at him carefully before

asking,

“Will their general truly be there?”

The prince gave a tired sigh.

“Maybe. At least... I hope so.”

He leaned back in his chair, closed his eyes, and muttered,

“It will be a bloody fucking night.”

Maesha walked toward him and sat beside him. She gently took his hand into hers and said softly,

“I trust you. I know you can do this.”

The prince opened his eyes and looked at her.

He saw the trust.

The hope.

The emotion burning within them.

And for the first time in many nights...
he smiled.

“Thank you.”

He reached up carefully, brushing a strand of hair away from her face and tucking it behind her ear.

“Go rest.”

Instead, Maesha pulled his head gently against her shoulder and kissed the top of his head before finally rising and leaving the hall.

And so the RedPrince remained alone—sitting in silence beneath the shadows, with only ghosts and spirits for company.

When dawn came,
and the first light of the sun touched
the mountains, the prince’s men took
their positions high above the valley.
They waited in silence for the enemy to

pass between the narrow cliffs below.
Every man held his breath.
It was today... or never.
At last, the enemy arrived.
The prince watched them carefully for a
moment before raising his hand and
giving the signal.
At once, the archers drew their bows
and released.
Arrows fell from the heights like rain—
like fire descending from the heavens.
The enemy soldiers screamed as men
and horses collapsed beneath the
storm of steel. Bodies fell across the
rocky path as panic spread through the
valley.
The ambush was merciless.
When the slaughter ended, the prince's



Art by John Doe

men climbed down from the cliffs and surrounded the large chariot where the enemy general was supposed to be riding.

They tore open the heavy doors—
but the chariot was empty.

No general.

The soldiers exchanged confused and uneasy looks.

They searched the valley, the wagons, and even the corpses lying among the rocks.

Nothing.

Then—

the sound of approaching horses echoed through the valley.

Everyone turned.

A group of riders emerged from the

morning mist. At their front rode Lord Castor Aklagard, accompanied by six soldiers.

Castor had once been one of the most loyal men to Donarall's father.

The prince's soldiers immediately raised their weapons toward them.

Beside the prince, Maesha whispered softly,

"Father...?"

The prince looked at her in surprise before turning back toward the rider.

"Lord Castor?" he said cautiously. "I believed you were dead."

Castor smiled faintly beneath his grey beard.

"No."

Then his eyes shifted toward Maesha.

“My daughter and I have spent years trying to reclaim what belongs to you.”

The prince slowly turned toward Maesha.

“You never told me you were an Aklagard.”

She smiled warmly at him.

“If I had, you would have ruined the plans, you idiot.”

For the first time in a long while, the prince almost laughed.

Then he faced Lord Castor once more.

Castor’s expression darkened slightly as he spoke:

“General IronHand is dead. Tomorrow, return to your home... and you shall be crowned beneath the blessing of the pastors.”

For a moment, the entire valley fell silent.

The war that had consumed Donarall's life suddenly felt... over.

Lord Castor bowed his head respectfully before turning his horse away.

And without another word, he rode into the morning fog.

The next day, the crowning hall was filled with life once more.

The ancient Temple of Kings stood crowded with nobles, lords, ladies, knights, and priests. For the first time in many years, Redcastle no longer felt like a kingdom drowning in war.

As Donarall entered the great hall, four royal guards walked behind him.

One of them stepped forward and shouted loudly enough for the entire temple to hear:

“Hail to His Grace!”

At once, the entire hall knelt before him.

The guard continued,

“King Donarall of House Aelardenia, Third of His Name, King of the Snake, the Dark, the Light, and the Eagle... King of Men and Women... Sword of Light and Fire... Future Navigation.”

The words echoed across the massive hall.

Slowly, Donarall walked toward the high priests.

When he reached them, he knelt.

The oldest priest lifted the ancient

crown of Redcastle and gently placed it upon Donarall's brow.

For a moment, the hall became completely silent.

The RedPrince had become king.

Then another set of doors opened.

Four more guards entered behind Maesha.

"Hail to the new queen!"

Once again, the hall knelt.

The guard announced her titles proudly:

"Lady Maesha, daughter of Lord Castor... Queen of the Snake, the Dark, the Light, and the Eagle... Queen of Men and Women... Princess of House Aklagard."

Maesha walked gracefully through the

hall until she reached the priests.
She knelt beside Donarall and slowly
offered him her hand.
He took it gently into his own.
Then the priest raised his voice before
the gods and the people:
“In the name of the gods... in the name
of the Light... in the name of the Dark...
and beneath the curse of the Snake... I,
priest of these lands, recognize King
Donarall as the one true ruler who shall
guide us into light beside his wife,
Queen Maesha. May they rule long
enough to know peace.”
The king and queen rose together.
And the entire hall erupted into
applause.



That evening, after the celebrations,
the music, and the endless joy that
filled the halls of Redcastle, King
Donarall believed he had finally
achieved it all.

Peace.

The crown.

The throne his father had died for.

At last, the war was over.

With a tired but genuine smile upon his
face, he entered his chambers.

The room was quiet.

There, beside the firelight, sat Maesha
alone, calmly playing a game of chess
against herself.

When she noticed him, she smiled
softly and rose from her seat before
slowly walking toward him.

“Hello, husband.”

Donarall stepped closer and wrapped his arms around her, pulling her impossibly near.

He brushed the strands of hair from her face and tucked them gently behind her ear.

“Hello, wifey.”

For a brief moment, everything felt peaceful.

Then Maesha asked quietly,

“I have a question... Who do you think rules stronger? A king... or a queen?”

Donarall thought for a moment before answering honestly,

“I think a king.”

Maesha gave a small giggle.

“Oh, really?”

Her eyes remained fixed upon his.

“You became king because I made you one.”

The warmth in the room suddenly felt colder.

Then she whispered,

“And now... I will return you to what you once were.”

Confusion crossed his face.

“What do you mean?”

She did not answer.

Instead, Donarall suddenly felt something sharp press into his stomach.

A knife.

His eyes widened as he slowly looked down at the blade buried within him.

Then he looked back at her.

Maesha was trembling.
She was trying not to cry—trying to
convince herself that what she was
doing was necessary.
But love made her weak.
Love made her tears fall anyway.
Still... she did not apologize.
She guided him gently onto the bed
and stayed beside him as his strength
slowly faded away.
The great RedPrince—the exiled boy
who crossed the sea, who fought for a
stolen throne, who became a living
legend—could do nothing now except
stare at the woman he loved.
Until, at last...
his eyes closed.
And King Donarall was gone.

Maesha knelt beside his lifeless body,
tears falling silently onto her cheeks as
she looked upon his face one final time.
With trembling fingers, she closed his
eyes gently and kissed his forehead.
“I’m sorry.” she whispered.
Then she kissed his forehead once
more.
Slowly, she reached for the crown
resting beside him.
And placed it upon her own brow.
That night, a new reign began.
A new government rose.
And for the first time in the history of
Redcastle—
a woman ruled the kingdom alone.
Thus ended the story of Donarall of
House Aelardenia...

The RedPrince.

The King Who Never Was.

